

First, photos and videos. These are usually the largest category for phone users. A casual stream of family pictures, screenshots and social-media saves accumulates surprisingly fast, and video multiplies the problem.

Second, email. If you use Gmail heavily, remember that Google storage is shared across Gmail, Drive and Photos. So the innocent thought “I only need cloud storage for photos” can become dangerously wrong if your mailbox is also crammed with years of attachments, resumes, invoices, forwarded image dumps and PDF-heavy threads. One full Gmail account can throttle the same storage pool your photo backup depends on.

Third, chat backups and media. WhatsApp is one of the stealthiest storage eaters in Indian homes because it sits at the junction of family groups, work groups, school groups and “temporary” downloads that achieve immortality by never being deleted. WhatsApp’s official help pages tell users to go into Storage and data > Manage storage to identify large items and chats, and they specifically note that backup files can vary in size. That is your warning sign: one person’s WhatsApp backup may be small, another’s may be absurd.

Fourth, downloaded media and duplicates. Offline OTT downloads, Telegram files, camera exports, old ZIP files, desktop clutter and duplicate photos can create a false impression that you “need more cloud,” when what you actually need is a ten-minute cleanup.

Fifth, creative and work files. These include Lightroom catalogs, RAW photos, PSDs, video projects, CAD files, podcasts, large PowerPoint presentations, archived magazine layouts and years of document versions. If you create for a living, your storage maths is completely different from that of a typical casual user.

That is why there is no single correct answer to “How much storage do I need?” There are only user profiles.

The casual user: 50GB to 100GB

A casual user is someone who mostly stores:

- everyday phone photos
- some short videos
- a manageable email inbox
- personal documents
- a few app backups

If that sounds like you, you often do not need 1TB. For an iPhone user, Apple’s 50GB iCloud+ tier may be enough at the start if the device is not overloaded with years of media and if you are reasonably disciplined about pruning junk. For a Google user, however, the calculation is trickier because the free 15GB is shared across Gmail, Drive and Photos, so many people hit the wall faster than they expect and end up needing at least 100GB to breathe comfortably. Microsoft’s 100GB-class entry through Microsoft 365 Basic makes similar sense for someone whose storage needs are modest but who wants headroom over the tiny free tier.



Step-by-step: how to check if you are a casual user

1. Look at your phone’s photo count and recent video habits.
2. Check whether your email storage is bloated with attachments.
3. Review cloud usage across all services, not just photos.
4. If you are nowhere near storage panic and mostly keep documents plus normal media, start small.
5. Upgrade only when your actual usage pattern proves you need it.

The trick is to avoid buying future chaos before chaos exists.

The family photo hoarder: 200GB to 2TB

This is the most common modern profile. The family photo hoarder is not irresponsible. They are just optimistic. They assume every school function, vacation clip, puppy video, wedding reel, baby milestone, and blurry Diwali picture deserves permanent residence in the cloud. Emotionally, that is understandable. Financially, it becomes 200GB surprisingly fast.

Google One’s plan structure in India makes this visible by offering 100GB for moderate needs and 2TB for much heavier storage use. Apple similarly jumps from 200GB to 2TB because family photo libraries do not grow linearly; they leap. A couple of active phone cameras, years of synced photos, shared family